

Name: \_\_\_\_\_

Date: \_\_\_\_\_

# How Do Bees Make Honey?

Grade 4 reading comprehension · Informational text · 14 points · About 20 minutes

## Collecting nectar

A honey bee starts with nectar, a sweet liquid inside flowers. The bee uses its long, straw-like tongue to suck up the nectar and store it in a special honey stomach. This is separate from the stomach where the bee digests its own food. A bee may visit dozens or even hundreds of flowers on a single trip. While it drinks, powdery pollen sticks to its body. When the bee lands on the next flower, some of the pollen rubs off, which helps that flower make seeds.

## Back at the hive

When its honey stomach is full, the bee flies back to the hive. A hive can hold tens of thousands of bees, and every worker has a job to do. The bee passes the nectar to another worker bee, mouth to mouth. This bee chews the nectar for a while and adds special enzymes. The enzymes change the nectar's sugars, which helps turn it into honey.

## Drying it out

Nectar is mostly water, so it is too runny to store. The bees spread it into the wax cells of the honeycomb. Then they fan their wings over it to blow air across the cells. As the water evaporates, the nectar becomes thick and sticky.

## Sealing the cells

When the honey is thick enough, the bees cover each cell with a lid of wax. Sealed honey can stay safe in the hive all winter, when there are few flowers. A single worker bee makes less than one teaspoon of honey in her whole life, so careful beekeepers take only the extra honey and leave enough for the bees to eat.

1. What is nectar, according to the text? (1 point)

2. Where does a bee keep the nectar while it flies back to the hive? (1 point)

3. The text says, “As the water evaporates, the nectar becomes thick and sticky.” What do you think “evaporates” means? Use clues from the sentence. (2 points)

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4. Why do you think the bees fan their wings over the honeycomb cells? (2 points)

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5. The text says nectar is “too runny to store.” Why do you think thick honey is easier to store? (2 points)

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6. The text says sealed honey can stay safe “all winter, when there are few flowers.” Why does this matter to the bees? (2 points)

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7. Number these steps 1 to 4 in the order they happen. (2 points)

- ☐ Bees fan their wings over the honeycomb.
- ☐ A bee collects nectar from flowers.
- ☐ Bees seal the cells with wax.
- ☐ A worker bee adds enzymes to the nectar.

8. Write one or two sentences that tell the main idea of the text. (2 points)

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**Writing task:** Imagine you are a worker bee. Write about your busiest day.

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